

Muaz Özcan

Ph.D. in Social and Organizational Psychology

Blacksburg, VA 24060, USA

✉ muazozcanva@gmail.com | ✉ mozcan17@ku.edu.tr

🌐 muazozcan.github.io | [in linkedin.com/in/muaz-ozcan](https://linkedin.com/in/muaz-ozcan)

EDUCATION

2025 **Ph.D. in Social and Organizational Psychology**

Koç University, Istanbul, Türkiye

(100% English Instruction, QS 2026 Ranking: 323)

Ph.D. dissertation title: The Role of Individuals' Self-Comparisons with Existing Leaders on Negative Leadership Attitudes

(Advisor: Prof. Dr. Zeynep Aycan)

GPA: 3.92 / 4.00

2016 **B.A. in Psychology**

Bilkent University, Ankara, Türkiye

(100% English Instruction, QS 2026 Ranking: 415)

(Advisor: Assoc. Prof. Selin Salman Engin)

GPA: 3.94 / 4.00, Top-ranked student of the class of 2016

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

2023 – 2025 **Research Assistant at Koç University, Türkiye**

Koç University Leadership Lab

Project Title: *Who Does Not Want to Become a Leader? Using Virtual Reality to Reduce Worries about Leadership* (PI: Prof. Dr. Zeynep Aycan)

Contributed to an interdisciplinary virtual reality research project examining whether immersive leadership simulations can reduce worries about leadership. Coordinated research teams responsible for field implementation, data management, and technical setup across partner organizations. Assisted in the development of leadership scenarios and virtual reality characters, operated Wizard-of-Oz interfaces during participant interviews to control virtual agents, and supervised the classification, recording, and organization of behavioral data for analysis using iMotions software.

Fall 2023 **Part-Time Lecturer at Kadir Has University, Türkiye**

Department of Psychology (Department Chair: Prof. Dr. Selahattin Adil Sarıbay)

PSYC 435: Psychology of Leadership and Followership

2021 – 2023 **Part-Time Lecturer at Koç University, Türkiye**

Department of Psychology (Department Chair: Prof. Dr. Aylin Küntay)

PSYC / MGMT 306: Industrial, Work & Organizational Psychology (Fall 2021, Spring 2022, Summer 2023)

PSYC 101: Introduction to Psychology (High School Summer & Winter Camps, 2022–2023)

Leading the Way to a Sustainable Future (GLLS Program, 2023)

New Perspectives on Leadership (BANUU ERASMUS+ Program, 2022)

2017 **Teaching and Research Assistant at Düzce University, Türkiye**

Department of Psychology (Department Chair: Prof. Dr. Metin Kılıç)

Conducted literature reviews, assisted with undergraduate courses, and proctored exams

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

- Fall 2023 **Part-Time Lecturer at Kadir Has University**
PSYC 435: Psychology of Leadership and Followership
(Undergraduate Course, Taught in English, 16 Students, In Person)
- Summer 2023 **Part-Time Lecturer at Koç University**
PSYC / MGMT 306: Industrial, Work & Organizational Psychology
(Undergraduate Course, Taught in English, 45 Students, Online)
- Summer 2023 **Lecturer at High School Summer Camp 2023 of Koç University**
PSYC 101: Introduction to Psychology
(Undergraduate Course Taught to High School Students, Taught in English, 30 Students, Online)
- Summer 2023 **Invited Speaker at Career Days Fair at Doğu Akdeniz University, Cyprus**
What Is Industrial and Organizational Psychology and What Do I/O Psychologists Do?
(Undergraduate Students, Turkish, In Person)
- 2023 **Workshop Instructor at GLLS Program of Koç University**
Leading the Way to a Sustainable Future: Exploring the Dynamic Relation Between Sustainability and Leadership
(Undergraduates, Taught in English, 17 Students, Hybrid)
- 2023 **Lecturer at High School Winter Camp 2023 of Koç University**
PSYC 101: Introduction to Psychology
(Undergraduate Course Taught to High School Students, Taught in English, Online)
- 2022 **Workshop Instructor at BANUU ERASMUS+ Project of the European Union**
New Perspectives on Leadership (Designing New Pathways for Employability and Entrepreneurship of Iraqi Students in Archeology and Cultural Heritage)
(Undergraduate Students, Taught in English with Simultaneous Arabic Translation, 17 Students, Online)
- Spring 2022 **Part-Time Lecturer at Koç University**
PSYC / MGMT 306: Industrial, Work & Organizational Psychology
(Undergraduate Course, 53 Students, Taught entirely in English, Hybrid)
- 2022 **Lecturer at High School Winter Camp 2022 of Koç University**
PSYC 101: Introduction to Psychology
(Undergraduate Course Taught to High School Students, Taught in English, Online)
- Fall 2021 **Part-Time Lecturer at Koç University**
PSYC / MGMT 306: Industrial, Work & Organizational Psychology
(Undergraduate Course, Taught in English, 97 Students, Online)

- **Teaching Assistantships at Koç University**

(Responsibilities included engaging with 30–100 undergraduate or graduate students each semester through course organization, exam grading, teaching select components of the course, and proctoring.)

- Research Methods in Psychology (Undergraduate Course), Spring 2021, Spring 2018
- Behavioral Genetics (Graduate Course), Fall 2020
- Psychological Testing and Measurement (Undergraduate Course), Spring 2020
- Industrial, Work and Organizational Psychology, Fall 2019, Summer 2018, Fall 2017
- Stress and Coping (Graduate Course), Fall 2019
- Cross-Cultural Management (Graduate Course), Spring 2019
- Evolutionary Psychology (Graduate Course), Fall 2018

- **Undergraduate Teaching Assistantship at Bilkent University**

(Responsibilities included engaging with 30 undergraduate students through course organization, exam grading, and proctoring.)

- Introduction to Statistics (Undergraduate Course)

LAB AFFILIATIONS

- 2017 – 2025 **Lab Member at Leadership Lab, Koç University**
<https://leadlab.ku.edu.tr/>
- 2015 – 2016 **Research Group on Co-Parenting Processes, Bilkent University**

RESEARCH INTERESTS

- Role of similarity with existing leaders on fit perceptions between self and leadership
- Cultural perspectives on leadership emergence
- Leadership and gender stereotypes

PUBLICATIONS

1. **Özcan, M.** (2021). The bottleneck metaphor of leadership culture: Explaining how shared understandings about leadership develop and impede diversity and effectiveness of leadership in groups. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 12, 184. <https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2021.635751>
2. Bellibas, M. Ş., Polatcan, M., **Özcan, M.**, & Akyürek, M. İ. (2024). School leadership in a non-western context: How is paternalistic leadership related to teacher well-being and commitment in collectivist versus individualistic school cultures? *Journal of Educational Administration*, 62, 433–447. <https://doi.org/10.1108/JEA-01-2024-0002>

MANUSCRIPTS IN PREPARATION

1. **Özcan, M.**, Demirag Burak, E. G., & Aycan, Z. Leadership style discrepancy and employees' worries about leadership: The mediating role of psychological safety. *Manuscript in preparation.*
2. **Özcan, M.**, Şaşmaz, A., & Aycan, Z. The role of self-comparisons with political party leaders on local political candidates' negative leadership attitudes. *Manuscript in preparation.*
3. **Özcan, M.** Toward a multilevel theory of leadership culture: How hierarchical and simultaneous cultural signals shape self-selection into leadership. *Manuscript in preparation.*
4. **Özcan, M.** Do gendered leadership culture cues influence leadership worries? An experimental study. *Manuscript in preparation.*

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

1. **Özcan, M.**, & Aycan, Z. (2023, August). *Leadership culture belongingness and reluctance to lead: Insights from two field studies* [Oral presentation]. The 27th European Regional Conference of Cross-Cultural Psychology, Limerick, Ireland.
2. Salman-Engin, S., McHale, J., Selçuk, E., Gençoğlu, B., **Özcan, M.**, Saçaklı, A., Yalın, R., & Günay, D. (2019, March). *Longitudinal associations between coparenting and marital adjustment during infancy in Turkish sample* [Poster presentation]. The Society for Research in Child Development Biennial Meeting (SRCD), Baltimore, MD.

AWARDS, FUNDING, AND OTHER SUPPORTS

2024	Koç University Graduate School of Social Sciences and Humanities Excellence Award (\$125 bonus)
2023	International Association of Cross-Cultural Psychology Solidarity Outreach Scheme (SOS) Fund (\$1,184 travel grant)
2023 – 2024	TUBİTAK 2250: Performance-Based Scholarship for PhD Students (\$2,400/yr bonus)
2023 – 2024	TUBİTAK 2247: National Outstanding Researchers Program Doctoral Bursary (\$8,400/yr stipend)
2017 – 2022	Koç University Graduate School Scholarship (\$38,000/yr tuition support + \$18,000/yr stipend)
2017 – 2022	TUBİTAK 2211-A: National Ph.D. Student Scholarship (\$8,000/yr stipend)
2012 – 2016	Bilkent University Full Merit Scholarship and High Honor Distinction for Undergraduate Students: based on academic performance (\$22,500/yr tuition support)

OTHER PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

- Principal consultant at the Assessment Day of the 2022 Global Learning and Leadership for Sustainability (GLLS) Mentorship Program of Koç University. Designed and administered the application form, created student selection criteria and toolset, and facilitated and monitored assessment day activities.

SERVICE TO THE PROFESSION

- Ad hoc reviewer, *The International Journal of Human Resource Management* (Taylor & Francis)

SKILLS

Data Analysis	SPSS, Mplus, R, G*Power
Research Tools	Covidence, iMotions, Qualtrics
Participant Platforms	Prolific, Amazon MTurk
Teaching Platforms	Blackboard, Moodle, Top Hat
Quantitative Methods	Structural Equation Modeling (SEM), Multilevel Modeling, Latent Profile Analysis (LPA), Mediation and Moderation Analysis, Regression (linear and logistic), Confirmatory and Exploratory Factor Analysis
Additional Methods	Meta-analysis, Experimental design, Power analysis, Qualitative analysis (content and focus group analysis)